

What to Do First

Who to call in the first hours, who to tell in the first days, and the information we'll ask you for when we meet.

SECTION 1

The First Call

One call is the whole of what has to happen right away

Call us at **206-242-1787**, any hour of the day or night. That call is the only thing that has to happen immediately. Everything else in this guide can wait, and most of it should. Where the death occurs changes who makes that first call, so here is each situation.

At home, under hospice care

Call the hospice nurse. The nurse comes out, completes their part, and calls us for you. You don't need to call 911.

At home, without hospice

Call 911. When a death at home wasn't under hospice or another at-home medical provider, the county has to release your loved one before we can bring them into our care. Tell the responders you've chosen Bonney Watson.

At a hospital

Tell the staff you've chosen Bonney Watson. They'll call us once their paperwork is complete, and we take it from there.

At a hospice or nursing facility

Same as the hospital. Tell the staff you've chosen Bonney Watson and they'll notify us for you.

Away from home

Call us anyway, even if the death happened in another state or country. We arrange the transportation home and coordinate with a funeral home where the death occurred, so you don't have to make those calls yourself.

If a pre-plan exists

Tell us on that first call. Most of the decisions are already made, and if your loved one was enrolled in the **Travel Plan by Inman**, transportation from anywhere is already covered.

SECTION 2

Who to Tell in the First Few Days

None of these calls have to happen in the first hour

Spread these over the first few days. This is also a good list to hand to family and friends who ask what they can do to help, because every call on it is one you don't have to make yourself.

The one we handle with you is the first: when you call us, we'll set a time to meet, usually within a day or two. If you own cemetery property at Washington Memorial Park, that call and the funeral home call are the same call.

Employers matter twice. The employer of the person who died may owe final wages or benefits, and relatives will need time off for the service.

CONTACT AS SOON AS YOU'RE ABLE

- **Us**, to set the arrangement appointment: 206-242-1787
- **Relatives and close friends**
- **The personal representative** named in the will
- **The cemetery** where you own or want property
- **Employers**: theirs, and anyone needing time off
- **Insurance companies**: life, health, accident
- **Religious, fraternal, civic and veterans organizations**, and unions
- **Their lawyer and accountant**

SECTION 3

The Information We'll Need

What the state asks for on the death certificate

We file the death certificate with the state of Washington, and the state asks for more than most families expect. Gathering this before our appointment saves you a second trip. Don't worry about having every answer. We work through the list together, and a blank can be filled in later.

Two of these trip people up. The state won't accept "retired" as an occupation, so think about what they did for most of their working life. And it asks for their mother's last name before her first marriage, which sometimes takes a call to an older relative.

If you'd rather work ahead, the **Vital Statistics Worksheet** collects all of this in one printable place.

VITAL STATISTICS CHECKLIST

- **Full legal name**, plus any other names they used (also known as)
- **Social Security number**
- **Date and place of birth**
- **Home address**, and how long they lived there
- **Highest level of education**
- **Usual occupation** and kind of business, not "retired"
- **Marital status**, and the surviving spouse's or partner's name
- **Parents' names**, including mother's last name before her first marriage
- **U.S. Armed Forces service**, yes or no

SECTION 4

Papers Worth Finding

Nothing here holds up the first call

These documents matter at the arrangement appointment and in the weeks after, not in the first hour. Look for them when you're able, and bring what you find.

Pre-plan paperwork

If your loved one planned ahead with us or with another funeral home, most decisions are already made and often already paid for.

DD-214 discharge papers

If they served in the military, this one document unlocks the VA benefits. The **Veterans Guide** covers what those are worth.

Life insurance policies

Each insurer needs its own claim, and many families use a policy to pay for the services themselves.

Cemetery paperwork

If they owned cemetery property, the Certificate of Interment Rights says where. If you can't find it, we can look it up for property here.

The will or trust

The personal representative needs it to settle the estate. The original matters; a copy is a starting point.

A note on death certificates

Most families end up needing 8 to 12 certified copies to settle accounts. We order those for you, so you don't need to do anything yet except know it's coming.

If someone has just died, stop reading here

Call us at **206-242-1787**, any hour. We'll bring your loved one into our care and walk through everything else in this guide with you, at the table, one step at a time.

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